

# The Isolator

Comedy sketch by Jubilian Ngaruwa, Thiago Silva, and Chloe Nunn

Edited by Laurence Pears

Two scientists, Al and Hu, are stood at a white topped table.  
They are in a science lab at a very prestigious research institution.  
The year is 1928.

*Al lifts a comically large petri dish from the table, staring at it in curiosity, and turns towards Hu.*

**Hu:** Al!.. Please put the experiment down very carefully. The presentation is in 20 minutes! My funding ends the moment I leave this lab, so we have one shot to make this happen.

*Relenting.*

**Hu:** ...But thank you for volunteering to help.

**Al:** No need to thank me.

*Hu smiles appreciatively.*

**Al:** I'm serious. I'm only here because I missed the meeting, and everyone knows you get shafted with the job no one else wants to do if you miss the meeting. I didn't even have time for lunch. Word to the wise – my box of raisins went missing yesterday from the communal fridge. This is a communal lab! what next? Equipment?.. I'll catch the culprit. Little does the thief know, I've labelled everything with invisible ink: *"Do Not Touch – This item is the property of Alexander..."*

**Hu:** HOW IS THAT IMPORTANT RIGHT NOW!

*Hu relents.*

**Hu:** Sorry, Al... and thank you. I think you're in for a real treat – you're about to watch history be made!

**Al:** oh you mean like your helmet thingy?

**Hu:** helmet thingy... *Incredulous*

*Hu lifts the Isolator helmet from beneath the table. It looks like a goldfish bowl painted white.*

**Hu:** The "Isolator" helmet enhances concentration by blocking sound, vision, and limiting oxygen. When wearing this, it increases focus by thirty percent. When the subject has this on – what cannot be accomplished?!

**Al:** *rolls eyes...shallow breathing*

*Hu ignores or hasn't heard Al's comment.*

**Hu:** now, to prepare for this experiment every variable must be accounted for. Al could you get the checklist? *pointing to a clipboard across the table*

*Al picks up the checklist and hands it to Hu*

**Hu:** clean environment

*Al sprays a bottle of cleaning product in the air. Hu engrossed in the list and his petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** sample prepared

*Al hands Hu gloves, tweezers, tubes of substances etc. Hu dons all equipment and adds everything to the petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** silence

*Al closes windows and doors.*

**Al:** *whispers...check*

**Hu:** *whispers...no light*

*Al turns lights off. Everything goes black.*

**Al:** *whispers...check*

*Moment of quiet in the dark.*

**Hu:** *loudly...no no no no no, what's that noise I can hear*

*Sounds of stumbling around in the dark*

**Hu:** turn the lights back on. What can that be? Do you hear that? A high pitched whine or whistle?

*Lights come up. Al looks as if straining to hear something. Confused. Realises this is a moment to escape for a break.*

**Al:** I don't know! I can go find out though!

*Al exits. Hu busies himself. Al returns triumphantly holding a kettle and a mug of coffee.*

**Al:** found the culprit...and grabbed a refreshment.

*Al places kettle on a back table.*

**Hu:** this is not the time or place for refreshments!! You better not spill that in here.

*Al chugs coffee. Places mug at the back with the kettle.*

**Hu:** right. Attempt two.

**Hu:** clean environment

*Al sprays a bottle of cleaning product in the air. Hu engrossed in the list and his petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** sample prepared

*Al hands Hu gloves, tweezers, tubes of substances etc. Hu dons all equipment and adds everything to the petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** silence

*Awkward silence*

*Al nods obviously*

*Hu smiles and nods back in understanding. Gives Al a thumbs up.*

*Al turns lights off. Everything goes black.*

*Moment of quiet in the dark.*

*Strobe red and green lighting starts.*

*Hu lets out a sigh of frustration.*

**Hu:** What on earth is that now?!

*Lights come back up.*

**Al:** two ticks.

*Al Exits. He returns shortly.*

**Al:** Good news – found the source. Chap down the hall is trying to invent sound-activated lights. Bad news – he made them rather too sensitive. A simple conversation can set them off apparently. *(beat)* He's on his lunch break now though, speaking of, it is about that time isn't it ? Would you like a sandwich Hu?

*Al retrieves two sandwiches from his jacket and extends one to Hu.*

**Hu:** no! Put those away and make sure they don't leave crumbs anywhere in here. We can't have ANY contamination! We're so close to success.

*Al returns sandwiches to jacket pocket.*

**Hu:** ok, third times a charm.

**Hu:** clean environment

*Al sprays a bottle of cleaning product in the air. Hu engrossed in the list and his petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** sample prepared

*Al hands Hu gloves, tweezers, tubes of substances etc. Hu dons all equipment and adds everything to the petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** silence

*comically mouths C-H-E-C-K slowly*

*Hu smiles and nods back in understanding. Gives Al a thumbs up.*

*Al turns lights off. Everything goes black.*

*Moment of quiet in the dark.*

**Hu:** can you smell that? That won't do, there's something in here, I can smell it. It must be contaminating my sample.

*Lights come back up. Al looks entirely unimpressed. Wrinkling nose trying to smell the thing.*

**Hu:** I'll go this time, you stay here ...sternly... Back in a jiffy.

*Al spins around in boredom then remembers his sandwich. He takes it out and very carefully unwraps it trying to not get crumbs anywhere. He pauses, making sure Hu isn't about to come back in the room. He furtively takes a bite. Then another.*

**AI:** Egg and cress baby!

*Al starts to look around the room and comes closer to the petri dish containing the experiment. He leans over while still holding the sandwich. He leans closer. He takes a bite of his sandwich.*

*He fumbles, the sandwich falls out of his hands and plops down right in the petri dish. Al looks panicked.*

*He immediately picks the sandwich up, but is alarmed at what has happened. It flicks out of the dish and lands on the table next to it. Crumbs are scattered everywhere.*

*Al hastily grabs the sandwich, finishes it in one mouthful. He picks up the petri dish, blows on it to 'clean' it. Wipes the crumbs off table & push crumbs under table with foot( if feet are visible) just as the door handle turns.*

*Hu enters with urgency.*

**Hu:** right well it turns out someone made an egg salad in the kitchen and the fumes were making their way all the way down to our lab here..

*Al looks around trying to take attention off himself, having just consumed an egg salad sandwich.*

**Hu:** but I think we are all set to try again this time. *checking his watch* Yes, just enough time

*Al nods, slightly sheepishly.*

**Hu:** clean environment

*Al sprays a bottle of cleaning product in the air, he goes for slightly more this time, and sprays a little on the table too. Hu seems impressed at Al's renewed dedication to the task.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** sample prepared

*Al hands Hu gloves, tweezers, tubes of substances etc. Hu dons all equipment and adds everything to the petri dish.*

*Al looks wincingly at Hu as he again prepares the sample in the petri dish.*

**Al:** check

**Hu:** silence

*Hu hears a noise and freezes*

**Hu:** (whispers) ...What's that hum?

*They both look around hurriedly. Hu searches all over. We see Al zone in on a small lamp on the table. He turns the bulb – the humming stops. Hu freezes, watching him. The humming then continues. Hu turns it a little more... it stops... then hum starts again. ( this motion Repeats, growing quicker.) Finally, Hu leans beneath the counter and comes up with the plug.*

**Al:** Ahhhh... that's why they pay you the big bucks.

**Hu:** Shhh...

*They both listen. The humming has stopped. Just as they move to continue the experiment, the humming begins again.*

*The search continues with even more vigour! Hu growing slightly more reckless with his searching, whilst looking at his watch*

*Al looks beneath the countertop they're working on.*

**Al:** Found it. It's Turing's thinking engine thingy – he's left it crunching numbers.

**Hu:** ...Unplug it.

**Al:** He said it was important.

**Hu:** So is this. Unplug it.

*Al does so. The humming stops momentarily. They are relieved... then it continues.*

**Al:** It's probably got phantom power. If we leave it a few minutes it'll probably stop.

*As Al speaks, Hu checks his watch. He makes a painful decision, pulls out a hammer from beneath the counter and hits the machine. We hear rudimentary metal and smashing noise. (Use a box full of aluminium cans beneath the table.)*

*They share a look of horror... then listen. There is silence.*

**Hu:** Proceed with the experi-

*The hum is back. They both look around. Hu spots a fly and points (it is making the buzzing Hum). Both their heads follow his finger. After circling and a few loop-the-loops, the fly lands on Al's forehead. Hu lifts the hammer. Al mimes 'NO', keeping his head frozen. Hu relents, picks up a newspaper and hits Al on the forehead.*

**Al:** Owwww!

**Hu:** Shhh!

*They listen. There is silence.*

**Hu:** Lights off

**Al:** Check

*Lights go off.*

**Hu:** Proceeding with the experiment. I've got good feeling about this.

**Narrator:** The experiment was a colossal failure. Hugo Gernsback's funding did indeed run out – as did he, later that day, amid rumours that he had destroyed the first Thinking Engine Thingy.

Al went on holiday with complaints of a headache and upon his return was shocked to discover that he had been given all Hu's equipment. It was explained to him by the caretaker that while cleaning up crumbs, he had found everything in the lab labelled "Hands off – this is the property of Alexander Fleming" in invisible ink, and thought it only right to return it to him.

*During this narration we see a black light torch illuminate the petri dish with a glowing substance in it , the light slowly moves up to reveal 'Hands off - this is the property of Alexander Flemming'..*

Al, or Alexander, discovered a mold growing in the petri dish from his sandwich. The mold had killed all the bacteria in the dish, and so it was that Alexander Flemming discovers Penicillin.

He would go on to win the Nobel Peace prize

Although in response to his invitation to the award ceremony he said 'I am so delighted to have been honoured in this way, however I am unable to attend due to an infection. I think it must have been something I ate...